

NCIE Innovation & Startup Policy

NCIE INNOVATION & STARTUP POLICY

National Council for Innovation & Entrepreneurship (NCIE)

Policy Area: Innovation, Entrepreneurship & Startup Development

Applicable To: Students, Youth, Innovators, Entrepreneurs, Startups, Educational Institutions and Eligible Ecosystem Partners

Policy Status: Institutional Programme Policy

Alignment: Innovation, Entrepreneurship, Technology, Youth Development and the broader national aspiration of **Viksit Bharat @2047**

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1. POLICY PREAMBLE

The **National Council for Innovation & Entrepreneurship (NCIE)** recognises innovation and entrepreneurship as important pathways for developing future-ready skills, creating employment opportunities, strengthening institutions and encouraging technology-led solutions.

The NCIE Innovation & Startup Policy establishes an institutional framework for identifying, developing, validating, mentoring, incubating and facilitating the growth of innovative ideas and early-stage startup opportunities.

The Policy seeks to create a structured ecosystem connecting:

**STUDENTS → INNOVATORS → INSTITUTIONS → MENTORS
→ INDUSTRY → INCUBATORS → ACCELERATORS →
FUNDING ECOSYSTEM → INVESTORS → ENTERPRISE
DEVELOPMENT**

The policy is designed to complement the broader Indian innovation and startup ecosystem. Government initiatives such as Startup India provide pathways covering ideation, validation, mentorship, seed funding and investor connectivity.

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2. POLICY VISION

To build a structured and inclusive innovation and entrepreneurship ecosystem that enables students, youth, innovators and institutions to transform ideas into validated solutions, startups and sustainable enterprises.

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3. POLICY MISSION

NCIE shall seek to:

- Promote innovation and creative problem-solving.
 - Encourage entrepreneurship among students and youth.
 - Develop technology and business capabilities.
 - Facilitate startup idea development and validation.
 - Encourage prototyping and proof-of-concept development.
 - Provide appropriate mentorship and expert guidance.
 - Strengthen institutional innovation ecosystems.
 - Facilitate incubation and acceleration linkages.
 - Promote industry–academia engagement.
 - Facilitate appropriate funding and investor ecosystem connections.
 - Encourage responsible and sustainable entrepreneurship.
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4. POLICY OBJECTIVES

The objectives of this policy are to:

1. Establish a structured innovation-to-enterprise pathway.
2. Encourage students to identify real-world problems and develop solutions.
3. Support innovators in developing ideas into structured concepts.
4. Facilitate prototype and proof-of-concept development.
5. Provide appropriate mentorship and technical guidance.
6. Encourage entrepreneurship and startup creation.
7. Strengthen innovation and entrepreneurship infrastructure in educational institutions.
8. Facilitate connections with incubators, accelerators and industry.
9. Support investor-readiness of suitable startup initiatives.
10. Facilitate access to appropriate funding opportunities, subject

to eligibility and availability.

11. Promote ethical, responsible and inclusive innovation.
12. Establish measurable innovation and startup outcomes.

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5. SCOPE OF THE POLICY

This policy may apply to NCIE programmes and initiatives involving:

Students

- School students
- College students
- University students
- Technical and professional students

Innovators

- Student innovators
- Independent innovators
- Researchers
- Technology innovators

Entrepreneurs

- Aspiring entrepreneurs
- Student entrepreneurs
- Early-stage founders
- Innovation-driven enterprises

Institutions

- Colleges
- Universities
- Schools
- Innovation centres
- Incubation centres
- Entrepreneurship development cells
- Other eligible educational and institutional organisations

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6. NCIE INNOVATION ECOSYSTEM

NCIE shall seek to develop an interconnected ecosystem:

PROBLEM IDENTIFICATION



IDEA GENERATION



INNOVATION



PROTOTYPE



VALIDATION



MENTORSHIP



INCUBATION



BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT



INVESTOR READINESS



INVESTOR / INDUSTRY CONNECTIVITY



STARTUP DEVELOPMENT



SCALE-UP

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7. INNOVATION DEVELOPMENT FRAMEWORK

NCIE programmes may support innovation through:

- Design thinking
- Problem identification
- Idea generation
- Research orientation
- Technology exploration
- Product development
- Process innovation
- Social innovation
- Digital innovation
- AI-enabled innovation
- Sustainability-oriented innovation

Innovation activities may be delivered through:

- Workshops
- Hackathons
- Competitions
- Innovation challenges
- Projects
- Seminars
- Mentorship programmes
- Institutional innovation programmes

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8. STUDENT INNOVATION POLICY

NCIE encourages students to participate in innovation activities irrespective of their academic discipline, subject to programme-specific eligibility.

Students may be encouraged to:

- Identify real-world problems.

- Develop innovative solutions.
- Participate in innovation challenges.
- Develop prototypes.
- Present ideas.
- Work in multidisciplinary teams.
- Participate in startup development activities.
- Seek mentorship.
- Explore incubation opportunities.

Student innovation projects may be assessed on:

- Problem relevance
- Originality
- Innovation
- Feasibility
- Technical potential
- Social or economic value
- Scalability
- Sustainability

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9. STARTUP DEVELOPMENT POLICY

NCIE shall encourage the progression of suitable innovations towards entrepreneurship.

The startup development pathway may include:

STAGE 1 – IDEATION

Identification of a problem, opportunity or innovative concept.

STAGE 2 – VALIDATION

Assessment of the problem, proposed solution and potential users.

STAGE 3 – PROTOTYPING

Development of prototype, MVP or proof of concept.

STAGE 4 – BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT

Development of business model, value proposition and market strategy.

STAGE 5 – MENTORSHIP

Access to appropriate experts, entrepreneurs, academics and industry professionals.

STAGE 6 – INCUBATION

Facilitation towards suitable incubators or startup support ecosystems.

STAGE 7 – INVESTOR READINESS

Preparation for potential investor engagement.

STAGE 8 – SCALE-UP

Facilitation towards appropriate industry, investment and growth opportunities.

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10. DR. A.P.J. ABDUL KALAM STARTUP VALIDATION PROGRAMME

The **Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Startup Validation Programme** shall operate as a major startup-oriented initiative within the NCIE innovation ecosystem.

The programme may provide a structured pathway covering:

**IDEA → PROTOTYPE → VALIDATION → MENTORSHIP →
INCUBATION → INVESTOR READINESS → ECOSYSTEM
CONNECTIVITY**

For selected eligible startup initiatives, the NCIE programme framework may provide **indicative seed support up to ₹5,00,000**, subject to applicable programme guidelines, evaluation, selection, milestones and availability of resources.

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11. STARTUP VALIDATION FRAMEWORK

Startup proposals may be evaluated against:

- Problem significance
- Innovation
- Technical feasibility
- Product readiness
- Market opportunity
- User need
- Business model
- Team capability
- Scalability
- Sustainability
- Social or economic impact

Validation does not constitute a guarantee of funding, investment or commercial success.

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12. INCUBATION & ACCELERATION POLICY

NCIE may facilitate suitable innovators and startups towards appropriate:

- Incubators
- Accelerators
- Innovation centres
- Entrepreneurship development cells
- Industry programmes
- Startup support organisations
- Mentorship networks

Selection and admission into an external incubator or accelerator shall remain subject to the respective organisation's eligibility and selection process.

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13. MENTORSHIP POLICY

NCIE may establish a mentor network comprising:

- Entrepreneurs

- Industry professionals
- Academicians
- Researchers
- Technology experts
- Business professionals
- Startup founders
- Subject-matter experts

Mentorship may cover:

- Product development
- Technology
- Business models
- Market validation
- Intellectual property
- Leadership
- Fundraising readiness
- Business strategy
- Startup operations

Mentorship shall be advisory in nature unless a separate contractual arrangement provides otherwise.

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14. INNOVATION & TECHNOLOGY MANAGEMENT

NCIE may promote technology-oriented innovation through programmes covering:

- Emerging technologies
- Artificial Intelligence
- Digital transformation
- Technology management
- Product innovation
- Technology entrepreneurship
- Digital business models
- Responsible technology adoption

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15. AI & STARTUP INNOVATION

NCIE may encourage responsible application of Artificial Intelligence in:

- Business
- Education
- Healthcare
- Agriculture
- Governance
- Social innovation
- Digital services
- Entrepreneurship
- Product development

Participants should be encouraged to consider:

- Data privacy
- Security
- Responsible AI
- Accuracy
- Human oversight
- Ethical use
- Applicable legal requirements

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16. INSTITUTIONAL INNOVATION POLICY

NCIE may facilitate eligible educational institutions in developing innovation and entrepreneurship ecosystems.

Potential institutional components include:

- Innovation Centres
- Incubation Centres
- Innovation Laboratories
- Entrepreneurship Development Cells
- Startup Clubs
- Innovation Clubs
- Student innovation programmes
- Faculty development
- Entrepreneurship training
- Industry–academia programmes

17. INSTITUTIONAL FUNDING FACILITATION

NCIE may facilitate eligible institutions in identifying and developing proposals for appropriate funding opportunities relating to innovation, entrepreneurship, incubation and institutional capacity building.

Potential funding channels may include:

- Government Ministries and Departments
- Government-supported schemes
- CSR partnerships
- Industry-supported programmes
- Innovation and incubation programmes
- Philanthropic organisations
- Institutional development programmes

Where appropriate, institutional proposals may be developed within an **indicative requirement range of ₹5 lakh to ₹25 lakh.**

This is a **potential funding-support framework and not a guaranteed Government, Ministry or CSR grant.**

Actual funding shall depend upon:

**ELIGIBILITY → PROPOSAL → EVALUATION → FUNDING
SOURCE → APPROVAL → AVAILABILITY OF FUNDS**

18. CSR & INDUSTRY PARTICIPATION

NCIE may engage eligible CSR and industry partners to support:

- Innovation programmes
- Student development
- Entrepreneurship
- Skills
- Technology
- Innovation infrastructure
- Institutional capacity building
- Social-impact innovation

Any CSR funding shall be subject to applicable CSR requirements, project eligibility, due diligence, corporate approval and the independent decision of the CSR contributor.

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19. INVESTOR CONNECTIVITY POLICY

NCIE may facilitate appropriate investor ecosystem connectivity for suitable and investor-ready startups.

Potential ecosystem stakeholders may include:

- Angel investors
- Venture capital funds
- Family offices
- Corporate investors
- Impact investors
- Startup investment networks
- Incubators
- Accelerators

Investor connectivity may include:

- Investor-readiness sessions
 - Pitch preparation
 - Demo days
 - Startup showcases
 - Investor introductions
 - Pitch opportunities
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20. INDICATIVE INVESTMENT PIPELINE

The NCIE startup ecosystem framework may seek to facilitate potential investor connectivity across eligible and investor-ready startup opportunities, with an **indicative investment pipeline of up to ₹25 crore**.

Important

The ₹25 crore figure represents a **potential ecosystem investment**

pipeline / connectivity framework and is **not guaranteed investment capital**.

Investment decisions remain entirely subject to:

- Investor interest
- Due diligence
- Startup quality
- Market potential
- Financial viability
- Technology readiness
- Legal compliance
- Investment terms
- Independent investor decision

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21. INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY POLICY

NCIE shall encourage innovators to appropriately consider intellectual property protection.

Depending on the nature of the innovation, participants may consider:

- Patents
- Copyright
- Trademarks
- Designs
- Trade secrets
- Other applicable IP protections

Unless separately agreed in writing, participation in an NCIE programme should not automatically be represented as transferring ownership of a participant's intellectual property to NCIE.

Participants should obtain appropriate professional/legal advice for IP protection and ownership matters.

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22. CONFIDENTIALITY

Participants may be required to protect confidential information relating

to:

- Unpublished inventions
- Business plans
- Technical information
- Customer information
- Financial information
- Proprietary processes
- Other confidential material

Where specific confidentiality obligations are required, they should be established through an appropriate written agreement.

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23. ETHICAL & RESPONSIBLE INNOVATION

NCIE encourages innovations that are:

- Ethical
- Inclusive
- Safe
- Sustainable
- Legally compliant
- Socially responsible

Projects involving potentially sensitive technologies, personal data, regulated activities or high-risk applications should undergo appropriate review and compliance checks.

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24. FUNDING & FINANCIAL PRINCIPLES

NCIE shall maintain the following principles:

- No funding shall be represented as guaranteed unless formally sanctioned.
- Funding opportunities shall be subject to eligibility.
- Financial assistance shall be subject to applicable programme rules.
- Investment opportunities shall remain subject to investor decisions.
- Appropriate documentation shall be maintained.

- Financial transactions shall follow approved procedures.
- Utilisation of programme funds shall be appropriately recorded.

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25. GOVERNMENT POLICY ALIGNMENT

The policy may be aligned thematically with national priorities relating to:

- Innovation
- Entrepreneurship
- Startup development
- Skill development
- Digital transformation
- Youth development
- Technology
- Industry–academia collaboration

Startup India officially identifies areas including **funding support, mentorship, industry–academia partnership, incubation and investor connectivity** within the startup ecosystem.

The policy may also complement educational and technology priorities reflected in national education initiatives, including technology-enabled learning and AI-related initiatives under the NEP 2020 ecosystem.

Such alignment **does not by itself establish Government ownership, statutory authority, Government accreditation, Ministry affiliation, Government endorsement or Government funding for NCIE.**

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26. PARTNERSHIP FRAMEWORK

NCIE may develop appropriate partnerships with:

Academic Institutions

Colleges, universities, schools and research institutions.

Industry

Companies, technology organisations and professional organisations.

Incubators & Accelerators

Innovation and startup ecosystem organisations.

Government & Public Institutions

Subject to applicable approvals, agreements and programme frameworks.

CSR Organisations

Eligible corporate CSR contributors.

NGOs & Community Organisations

For social innovation and community-oriented entrepreneurship.

Investors

Subject to independent investor interest and due diligence.

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27. INNOVATION CHALLENGES & HACKATHONS

NCIE may organise:

- Hackathons
- Innovation competitions
- Idea challenges
- Startup challenges
- Prototype competitions
- Innovation showcases
- Entrepreneurship competitions

Evaluation may consider:

- Innovation
- Problem relevance
- Technical feasibility
- Market potential
- Social impact
- Presentation
- Team capability
- Scalability

28. STUDENT STARTUP SUPPORT

Students may be provided with opportunities for:

- Startup orientation
- Innovation training
- Mentorship
- Prototype development
- Business model development
- Startup validation
- Incubation linkage
- Investor-readiness development

Participation in startup support programmes does not automatically establish startup recognition or Government recognition. Where applicable, startups may independently seek recognition under the relevant official framework, such as DPIIT Startup Recognition.

29. INSTITUTIONAL INNOVATION SCORECARD

NCIE may develop an institutional assessment framework covering:

Area	Indicative Assessment
Innovation infrastructure	Innovation / incubation facilities
Student participation	Innovation and startup participation
Faculty engagement	Mentoring and project support
Entrepreneurship	Startup activities
Industry engagement	Industry interaction
Innovation projects	Projects and prototypes
Startup outcomes	Validated ventures

Events	Hackathons and challenges
Mentorship	Expert engagement
Impact	Measurable outcomes

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30. MONITORING & EVALUATION

NCIE may monitor:

Inputs

- Trainers
- Mentors
- Institutions
- Resources
- Programme infrastructure

Outputs

- Participants
- Innovation projects
- Prototypes
- Mentorship sessions
- Workshops
- Institutions onboarded

Outcomes

- Skills developed
- Ideas validated
- Startups progressed
- Institutional capacity strengthened
- Industry connections developed

Impact

- Startup progression
- Employment / enterprise outcomes where verifiable
- Innovation adoption
- Institutional ecosystem development
- Social and economic contribution

31. DATA & DIGITAL GOVERNANCE

Programme information may be maintained through appropriate digital systems for:

- Registration
- Attendance
- Project tracking
- Mentorship
- Assessment
- Certification
- Institutional records
- MIS
- Monitoring

NCIE should implement appropriate controls relating to:

- Access
- Data accuracy
- Privacy
- Security
- Retention
- Authorisation

32. GRIEVANCE & FEEDBACK MECHANISM

Participants and institutions may be provided appropriate channels for:

- Programme feedback
- Complaints
- Grievances
- Technical issues
- Certification issues
- Institutional concerns
- Programme-related queries

Complaints should be recorded and addressed through an appropriate designated process.

33. GOVERNANCE & RESPONSIBILITY

The implementation of this policy may involve:

NCIE GOVERNANCE



PROGRAMME MANAGEMENT



INNOVATION & STARTUP PROGRAMME TEAM



INSTITUTIONAL / REGIONAL COORDINATORS



TRAINERS & MENTORS



PARTICIPANTS

Roles and responsibilities should be documented through applicable programme guidelines and internal procedures.



34. POLICY REVIEW

This policy should be periodically reviewed to consider:

- Programme outcomes
- Stakeholder feedback
- Regulatory developments
- Technology changes
- Startup ecosystem developments
- Institutional requirements
- Funding environment

- Emerging innovation opportunities

Policy amendments should be approved through the appropriate NCIE governance mechanism.

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35. CORE POLICY PRINCIPLES

NCIE's Innovation & Startup Policy shall be guided by:

INNOVATE

Encourage new ideas and solutions.

VALIDATE

Test ideas against real-world needs.

MENTOR

Provide appropriate guidance.

INCUBATE

Connect suitable ventures with support ecosystems.

CONNECT

Build industry, institutional and investor relationships.

CREATE

Promote entrepreneurship and enterprise development.

SCALE

Support suitable ventures towards growth opportunities.

IMPACT

Measure meaningful outcomes.

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36. NCIE INNOVATION-TO-ENTERPRISE MODEL

LEARN

Knowledge and awareness



INNOVATE

Ideas and solutions



BUILD

Prototype and proof of concept



VALIDATE

Technical and market assessment



MENTOR

Expert guidance



INCUBATE

Ecosystem support



CONNECT

Industry and investor ecosystem



CREATE

Startup / enterprise development



SCALE

Growth and expansion



IMPACT

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37. POLICY STATEMENT

NCIE is committed to fostering an enabling environment for innovation and entrepreneurship by providing structured learning, mentorship, validation, institutional support and appropriate ecosystem linkages for students, youth, innovators, startups and educational institutions.

The NCIE Innovation & Startup Policy seeks to establish a responsible and transparent pathway from idea generation to innovation, validation, incubation, entrepreneurship and potential investment connectivity, while ensuring that all funding, investment and institutional support remain subject to applicable eligibility criteria, due diligence, approvals, availability of resources and independent decisions of the relevant funding or investment stakeholders.

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38. FINAL POLICY FRAMEWORK

NCIE INNOVATION & STARTUP ECOSYSTEM

STUDENTS & YOUTH



INNOVATION



INNOVATION-LED IMPACT

Policy Alignment

NCIE INNOVATION & STARTUP POLICY

- **Innovation**
- **Entrepreneurship**
- **Technology**
- **Youth Development**
- **Institutional Strengthening**
- **Startup Ecosystem Development**
- **Viksit Bharat @2047 Contribution**